

William Hazlitt

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William Hazlitt was born in Maidstone in 1778, the youngest of three children of the Revd. William Hazlitt, a Unitarian minister who had studied at the University of Glasgow, where he was taught by Adam Smith.

The family moved to Ireland and then to the United States, but returned to Wem in Shropshire in 1787. In 1793, Hazlitt was sent to a Unitarian college in Hackney, London, where he received a broad education. One of his teachers was Joseph Priestley, an impassioned commentator on current political issues. While there, he read widely and formed a strong belief in liberty, the rights of man, and the importance of individuals being able to effect beneficial change by adhering to strong beliefs. As he wrote later, "I have a hatred of tyranny, and a contempt for its tools ---I cannot sit quietly down under the claims of barefaced power."

In 1798, he met Coleridge and was later invited to stay and met Wordsworth. They were all fired with ideas of liberty and the rights of man, and Hazlitt benefitted greatly from these friendships.

However, he had to start earning a living. He went to stay with his brother John, a successful painter of miniature portraits, and decided to become a painter himself. Within 3 years, he had a painting accepted for the summer exhibition at the Royal Academy. He painted portraits of Coleridge and Wordsworth, though neither liked them; Hazlitt was more concerned with producing an accurate portrait than one which would be liked by the sitters.

In 1803, William Godwin held a dinner party at which Hazlitt met Charles Lamb and his sister Mary; they remained firm friends. In 1808, Hazlitt married Sarah Stoddart, a friend of Mary's. The couple had three sons, only one of whom survived infancy.

In 1812, Hazlitt started another phase of his life, becoming a journalist, essayist and lecturer. He was hired by the Morning Chronicle as a parliamentary reporter, and later worked as drama critic, literary critic, and political



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essayist. He also contributed essays to The Examiner. With a more established income, he moved his family into a house in Westminster which had at one time been occupied by John Milton, who was highly regarded by Hazlitt. His landlord was Jeremy Bentham.

Hazlitt idolised Napoleon as the hope of the common man against the oppression of "legitimate" monarchy. He took the defeat at Waterloo as a personal affront, became profoundly depressed, and started drinking heavily.

The last fifteen years of Hazlitt's life began quite well. He was earning enough money and producing good work. His "Characters of Shakespeare's Plays" was comprehensive and written for a general reader. His lecturing attracted a small

group of admirers, including John Keats.

But his marriage was failing; his relations with Wordsworth and Coleridge were deteriorating. He was evicted from his lodgings, and his wife finally broke with him. He retired for long periods to Winterslow, near Salisbury. While there, he pursued an unreciprocated obsession with the 19 year old daughter of his landlord. He then wrote "Liber Amoris", a fictional account of this episode, which scandalised many of his friends and provided ammunition for his detractors. However, he continued to write essays of remarkable variety and literary merit. Many were published in "Table Talk" and are considered among the best essays ever written in English.

Relief from loneliness and financial troubles came from his second marriage to a Scottish widow, Isabella Bridgwater. They toured Scotland and Europe. In August 1826 he returned to Paris to research his projected life of Napoleon. When he returned to London in August 1827, he learned that his wife was leaving him.

His last years were plagued with financial insecurity, illness and depression. He moved to rooms in Bouverie Street which he shared with his son. There is a plaque to him on the site. Then to Frith Street in Soho, where he died in September 1830.